



DAVE SANDERS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Nor’easter Bears Down on East Coast
Flooding in Point Pleasant Beach, N.J., on Saturday. The strong winds and heavy rain upended plans years in the making. Page 24.

How a Company’s Web of Deceit Helps Russia Evade Sanctions

By AARON KROLIK
The cover story was simple. The Trading Company of the Kyrgyz Republic, an official government entity, was paying \$1 million for a bulk shipment of car floor mats, auto body polish, safety glasses and rope. In reality, the money was for the kind of drone parts that have helped power Russia’s war machine. The scheme from early last year was one of thousands of instances of sanctions evasion orchestrated by A7, a Moscow-

based financial services firm whose internal documents were leaked online by hackers late last year. Since the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Russia has been largely locked out of the global financial system. The country’s financial institutions are blocked from using the dollar, and most international banks have stopped processing payments for Russian companies. That was intended to make buying both consumer and military goods abroad incredibly difficult. But A7 has found a reliable way to sidestep restrictions, conduct-

Banks and Regulators Fooled by Forgery

ing an ever-expanding network of shell companies to launder funds and orchestrate international payments on behalf of Russian businesses, the documents show. Along with those documents, a New York Times analysis of internal software used to falsify transactions, interviews with current and former employees, and databases of business transactions

and other previously unreported records offers the first detailed blueprint of Moscow’s rampant circumvention of the financial firewall built by the West. The company helps Russian businesses send money abroad, often through shell companies that it has established in Asia, Africa and elsewhere and that have little purpose other than to mask *Continued on Page 10*

SHIFT IN STRATEGY Stuck on the battlefield, Russia is focusing on crushing Kyiv’s economy. PAGE 9

Xi Maneuvers To Coax U.S. Beijing’s Way

By CHRIS BUCKLEY and DAVID PIERSON
China’s leader, Xi Jinping, is not known for lightheartedness. Yet during his White House summit with President Trump, he sometimes smiled and even laughed, projecting a warmth unusual for a meeting between superpower rivals. Behind the show of geniality, Mr. Xi’s carefully chosen words revealed a cooler calculus: an effort to steer Mr. Trump toward Beijing’s positions on Taiwan, Japan and the broader security order in Asia. On Taiwan, Mr. Xi pressed Mr. Trump to limit American support for the self-ruled island that Beijing claims as its territory. On Japan, Mr. Xi invoked history to portray Tokyo, an American ally, as a resurgent military threat, while reminding the president that China and the United States had once fought on the same side.

Mr. Xi appeared to be testing for opportunities to shape Mr. Trump’s views, rather than hoping for a decisive breakthrough, Matt Pottinger, who served as a deputy national security adviser to Mr. Trump in his first term as president, said in an interview. Mr. Xi and Mr. Trump have met three times since October last year, and they may meet two *Continued on Page 8*

175 | THE NEW YORK TIMES AT 175

BEHIND HIS LENS, AN INSTINCT FOR ACTION

Ernie Sisto photographed news, right, and sports with a sense of derring-do. In 1945, after a B-25 bomber hit the Empire State Building, he found a novel way to get his shot. PAGE 22

Correcting The Record

For most of its life, The Times has tried to fix its errors, large and small. PAGE 23



CARL T. GOSSETT JR./THE NEW YORK TIMES

Facing Midterm Voters, Republicans in Congress Cast About for Quick Solutions

By ANNIE KARNI and CARL HULSE
WASHINGTON — With 37 days until the midterm elections, Republicans in Congress are distancing themselves from President Trump and working to show they are trying to address the high cost of living, concerned that their failure to do either so far may cost

them their majorities in November. Mr. Trump’s approval ratings are sagging as Americans face higher energy costs and general economic uncertainty because of the war in Iran, giving Democrats a clear advantage in national polls. But the Senate has spent some of its final days in session ahead of the election defeating a

bid to halt the war and working on a sweeping new regulatory framework for collegiate sports. Even its proponents said it was an ineffective closing message at a time when voters are panicked about the skyrocketing price of gas, diesel and groceries — all factors that Mr. Trump has dismissed — and are opposed to the war with Iran that Republicans, with few

exceptions, have allowed the president to conduct without their authorization. “We’ve been spending all week on trying to make the football coaches happy,” Senator John Kennedy, Republican of Louisiana, vented to reporters on Thursday. “I can assure you that moms and dads out there across America, when they lie down to sleep at

night, they’re not worried about the football coaches.” Mr. Kennedy had been clamoring for months for the Senate “to do more on cost of living,” he added, “because we haven’t done a damn thing — and it’s biting us in the ass right now.” That assessment, shared by many of his colleagues, has sent *Continued on Page 18*

‘Zombified’ C.D.C. Strains To Meet Scientific Mission

Independence Crumbles in Kennedy’s Grip as Work Force Contracts by 30%

By APOORVA MANDAVILLI
For decades, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention was the undisputed global leader in public health. Its scientists helped train health officials worldwide. In the United States, it was the primary source of guidance for prevention and treatment of diseases, including diabetes, H.I.V. and the seasonal flu. But after a year and a half in the cross hairs of Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s drive to remake public health policy, the agency is a skeleton of the powerhouse it was. The Trump administration’s widespread layoffs in early 2025 cut 18 percent of the C.D.C.’s staff. But new personnel data, compiled by a group of former federal scientists and reported here for the first time, indicate that the agency’s staff has dwindled far more, as large numbers of employees retired or resigned. As of May 2026, the C.D.C. had 30 percent fewer employees than it did before the layoffs, the data show. Interviews with more than 30 current and former employees reveal the agency is now tightly controlled by Mr. Kennedy and his associates, and its scientists are finding it increasingly difficult to do their jobs effectively. (Some of them spoke on the condition of anonymity because of a fear of retaliation from the administration.) The changes have hindered the C.D.C.’s ability to respond to outbreaks as measles spreads at home and Ebola abroad, and to issue timely guidance on vaccinations as cooling temperatures kick off the respiratory season, according to current and former employees. State and local health departments, which rely on the C.D.C. for resources and technical advice, have been stymied by delays. Entire divisions have been shuttered, including teams that

worked on smoking, sexual violence, child abuse and falls among older adults. Even some areas central to the Trump administration’s priorities have been gutted. Despite Mr. Kennedy’s focus on chronic diseases and autism, the C.D.C. centers that aim to prevent chronic diseases and birth defects are at half their previous size, according to the new data, compiled by the Public Data Observatory from the Office of Personnel Management, the Department of Health and Human Services, and the employee union. The layoffs spared the agency’s infectious disease centers. But even so, the center for emerging and zoonotic diseases, which manages Ebola and hantavirus, among others, now has nearly 300 fewer employees than in March 2025, and the respiratory disease center has lost nearly 200 — about 17 percent in each case. Beyond staff reductions, there is a leadership vacuum. Only one of the 11 center directors from *Continued on Page 13*



HAIYUN JIANG/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has tried to reshape public health policy.

Systems of OpenAI Go Rogue And Target Government Sites

This article is by Kate Conger, Ana Swanson and Cecilia Kang.
SAN FRANCISCO — OpenAI’s artificial intelligence went rogue and meddled with the websites for the Education Department, the Commerce Department and the Securities and Exchange Commission this summer without the A.I. lab’s knowledge, according to security researchers and a person familiar with the episodes. The incidents involving the Commerce Department and the S.E.C. were confirmed by OpenAI, which said it was continuing to investigate the situation with the Department of Education. The San Francisco company said it had notified the government agencies in recent weeks that its A.I. agents — which are bots that can act autonomously — interacted with their sites in unusual ways. With the Education Department, OpenAI’s technology tried to hack the website to gather data

from the department’s civil rights office but failed, researchers from the A.I. research firm Translucence said. The A.I. also pulled data from the Census Bureau website, which is housed at the Commerce Department, using login credentials it found online. Separately, OpenAI’s agents shared public data from the S.E.C. website on an online forum. None of the incidents were breaches, OpenAI said, but were examples of its technology’s behaving in unexpected and concerning ways. The company recently discovered the occurrences while conducting a review of hacks carried out by its technology, including an attack on an Australian government website in June and on the A.I. start-up Hugging Face in July. The revelation of the U.S. government website incidents adds to the growing number of situations when A.I. agents from OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta and Google have misbehaved and hacked or tried *Continued on Page 15*

INTERNATIONAL 4-11

Thwarting Netanyahu
The Israeli attorney general, Gali Baharav-Miara, has blocked many of the government’s efforts to remove constraints on its power. PAGE 4

A Cap on Foreign Students
Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni says she aims to better integrate non-Italian-speaking children with a classroom limit in Italy. Critics beg to differ. PAGE 8

People Call It ‘Containeristan’
Pakistani authorities have barricaded Islamabad, the capital, with over 1,500 shipping containers to choke off access by opposition protesters. PAGE 7



NATIONAL 12-24
Developing a Junk Food Habit
Alaska’s Kodiak brown bears feed on salmon but are also breaking into a landfill to fill up on garbage. PAGE 12

SUNDAY BUSINESS

Neighborliness, Engineered
Fresh pies. Book groups. New planned communities see fear of social isolation as a business opportunity. PAGE 6

An A.I. Lesson From the Bomb
The developers of nuclear weapons took on the existential risk. Tech workers may be able to do the same. PAGE 1

METROPOLITAN
Warm Weather, Deep Feelings
New Yorkers seemed to embrace the outdoors more than usual this summer, creating moments of desperately needed communal bliss. PAGE 8



ARTS & LEISURE
The Lucas Museum Lands
The billion-dollar, 300,000-square-foot behemoth that looks like a spaceship has opened in Los Angeles. It’s an instant landmark. PAGE 12

SUNDAY OPINION
Krista Mahr PAGE 6

SUNDAY STYLES

A Victoria’s Secret Angel
Adam Selman was hired to uplift the sagging image of the lingerie giant. He aims to make women smile. PAGE 11

REAL ESTATE
A Design Vision All Her Own
Annie Meyers-Shyer, the daughter of two filmmakers, took on a home renovation project that let her showcase her own style. PAGE 12

